

The Third Level



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF JACK FINNEY

Jack Finney was born in Milwaukee, Wisconsin on October 2, 1911. Although his birth name was John Finney, he was renamed Walter Braden Finney at age three in honor of his father after his death. He graduated from Knox College in 1934 and began work at an advertising agency in New York City. While working there, Finney published his first article, "Someone Who Knows Told Me...", in the December 1943 issue of *Cosmopolitan*. This article, published during the height of the United States's involvement in World War II, discouraged American citizens from making careless remarks about the war efforts. Finney's experience living as a young adult during World War II would be influential on many of his works, including "The Third Level." In 1946, he published his first short story, "The Widow's Walk," and published his first novel, *Against the House*, in 1954. From the 1950s onwards, he was a prolific writer of science fiction, noir, and thrillers, and he became especially well-known for his 1955 novel *The Body Snatchers*. In 1987, he won the World Fantasy Convention's World Fantasy Award for Life Achievement. Finney passed away from pneumonia and emphysema in 1995; he was survived by his wife, Marguerite, and their two children, Kenneth and Marguerite.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Jack Finney published "The Third Level" in 1952, only seven years after the end of World War II. The war had a cataclysmic impact on the entire world, not only due to its massive death toll but also horrific events such as the Holocaust and the atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, both of which caused many people to question the inherent goodness of humanity. 1952 was also directly in the middle of the Korean War, which occurred between 1950-1953 and resulted in 3 million war-related deaths. This war was itself a proxy war spurred on by the Cold War between the United States and the Soviet Union, with the former supporting democratic South Korea and the latter supporting communist North Korea. The Cold War was an unsettling time for everyone on earth, as the escalating arms race between the United States and Soviet Union led to increased fear of a potentially world-ending nuclear war between the global powers. In essence, "The Third Level" was published during a period of immense societal trauma and instability, which explains its romanticization of the late 19th century, which was a time of peace in the United States (though, to be fair, 1894 wasn't *that* long after the end of the Civil War in 1865).

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Jack Finney's work reached notoriety in the 1950s, a period known as the "Golden Age" for American science fiction due to the high volume of iconic science fiction writers forging their careers and shaping the genre. Some of the early writers of the Golden Age included Isaac Asimov, Arthur C. Clarke, and Robert Heinlein, whose works granted science fiction more respectability due to their strong prose and complex themes. As for Finney's contemporaries, one particularly influential science fiction writer that also rose to popularity in the 1950s was Ray Bradbury, another writer who used science fiction themes to explore the pitfalls of modern humanity. Bradbury's 1952 story, "A Sound of Thunder," also focuses on time travel but approaches it from a significantly different perspective: rather than portraying time travel as a way to return to a simpler time as Finney does, Bradbury depicts time travel as a destructive force, with even the smallest changes in the past having potentially catastrophic echoes in the present. This hypothetical phenomenon, known as the "butterfly effect," has been credited to "A Sound of Thunder" and is a much more common approach to time travel in present-day science fiction than Finney's more idealistic depiction of it.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Third Level
- **When Written:** 1952
- **Where Written:** California
- **When Published:** October 1952
- **Literary Period:** Golden Age of Science Fiction
- **Genre:** Short Story, Science Fiction
- **Setting:** New York in the 1950s and Galesburg, Illinois in 1894
- **Climax:** After Charley gives up on his search for the third level, his friend Sam disappears. Charley then finds a letter from him in his stamp collection, indicating that Sam has traveled to 1894—the story then reveals that Sam was Charley's psychiatrist.
- **Antagonist:** Modern society
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

The Body Snatchers. The film *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* was based on Finney's novel *The Body Snatchers*, which was published just a year before the film, in 1955. As with many famous film adaptations of the 20th century, however, the film is now much more well-known than the book, to the point that

many people don't even know that the film is an adaptation at all.

Knox College. Finney's alma mater is Knox College, a small liberal arts college in Galesburg, Illinois—the same town that Charley, the protagonist of “The Third Level,” expresses great affection for. Knox College reciprocated this appreciation via the name of their literary magazine: *The Third Level*.



PLOT SUMMARY

“The Third Level” is set in 1950s New York, largely in **Grand Central Station**. Even though Grand Central Station only has two levels, the protagonist, Charley, believes that it has a secret third level. Although his psychiatrist believes Charley imagined the event due to his dissatisfaction with modern society, Charley disagrees with this assessment, claiming that everyone is dissatisfied with modern society and, thus, that he is not uniquely vulnerable to escapist daydreaming. Charley's psychiatrist—as well as his other friends—point to Charley's penchant for collecting **stamps** as evidence of his escapist nature, but Charley disagrees with this as well, since his grandfather grew up in peaceful times but started Charley's current stamp collection.

To prove his point, Charley recounts his experience of discovering the third level. He describes himself as a perfectly ordinary man. His only reason for being in Grand Central is to get home quickly to his wife, Louisa. However, in attempting to catch his train, he gets lost. While recounting this experience, Charley muses about the size and convoluted structure of the station and confesses that sometimes he believes the station is continuously growing new corridors like roots of a tree, with many tunnels that people don't even know about. Eventually, though, Charley reaches the end of the corridor he's in, where he discovers the third level.

Charley quickly realizes that the third level is unusual, owing to details such as open-flame gaslights, old-style attire, and an old locomotive. He checks the newspapers on the level and discovers that he's been transported back to the 19th century—specifically, the year 1894. Immediately, Charley realizes that buying tickets on the third level can transport him to the past permanently. He resolves to buy two tickets to **Galesburg, Illinois**—one for him, one for Louisa—since he loves the town in the present and imagines it will be even more lovely in 1894, back when people were friendlier and the World Wars were still many years away. However, when he attempts to buy the tickets, his modern currency is rejected by the suspicious clerk, and Charley quickly leaves to avoid arrest.

Afterwards, Charley spends \$300 to obtain \$200 of old currency, more than enough to live comfortably in 1894. Unfortunately, however, he is unable to find the third level

again. While Louisa initially discourages him from pursuing it, both she and Charley resume the search after their friend Sam disappears. Charley suspects Sam made it to 1894 and is proven correct when, one night, he finds a letter in his stamp collection addressed to his grandfather. Charley opens it to find a letter from Sam, who says he's living in 1894 Galesburg and loves it. Later, Charley discovers that Sam bought the equivalent of \$800 in old currency, which is more than enough money to fulfill his dream of opening a business. Sam, according to Charley, can't continue his modern-day job in 1894, since it doesn't exist yet. This, Charley reveals, is because Sam was his psychiatrist.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Charley – Charley is the protagonist of “The Third Level.” A 31-year-old **stamp** collector, Charley describes himself as a perfectly ordinary man who has nothing unusual about him and is in fact indistinguishable from most other adult men of his generation. His two most significant relationships are with his wife, Louisa, and his psychiatrist friend, Sam, although he feels alienated from both of them when they refuse to believe in his experience on the secret third level of **Grand Central Station**. Sam in particular credits this experience with Charley's imaginative and escapist nature, although Charley claims that his escapism is not unique to him, since most people want to escape the despair of modern society. Charley recounts his experience with the third level to the reader, revealing that the entire level exists in the year 1894 and thus allows individuals to travel back in time by buying train tickets. While Charley attempts to buy two tickets to **Galesburg, Illinois** for him and Louisa, he is unable to do so when the clerk rejects his modern currency. Although he is unable to discover the third level again, his experience is vindicated when he finds a letter from Sam in his grandfather's stamp collection revealing that Sam found the third level and made it to 1894 Galesburg.

Charley's Psychiatrist (Sam) – Charley's psychiatrist explains away Charley's encounter with the third level as a moment of mental escapism. In this way, he functions as the pragmatic and modern foil to Charley, who is much more open to unusual experiences and wishes to escape modernity. However, things take a dramatic turn at the end of the story when Charley discovers that his friend Sam has found the third level and, unlike Charley, was able to return to 1894 **Galesburg**. In the very last line of the story, it's revealed that Sam was actually Charley's psychiatrist. Since he cannot be a psychiatrist in the 19th century, Sam instead chooses to follow his true dream of opening a business with the large amount of old-time currency he was able to buy before his journey. With this ending, then, the story suggests that even people like Sam, who have ostensibly bought into the cold pragmatism of modern society,

desire the simpler life represented by the 19th century in the story.

Louisa – Louisa is Charley's wife. She is supportive of Charley and dislikes some of Sam's hypotheses about him, such as Sam's suggestion that Charley is unhappy. Even so, she is initially on Sam's side and does not want Charley to look for the third level again after hearing about his initial experience there. However, this soon changes after she and Charley discover that Sam has made it to 1894 via the third level. After learning this, she helps Charley resume his search for the third level, suggesting that she, too, longs to escape modernity for the past.

MINOR CHARACTERS

The Clerk – The clerk sells train tickets on the third level and thus acts as the gatekeeper to 1894. Charley attempts to buy tickets to **Galesburg** from him, but his modern currency arouses the clerk's suspicion and causes Charley to flee **Grand Central Station**.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



MODERNITY AND NOSTALGIA

In "The Third Level," Jack Finney uses time travel to explore the melancholy of modern life and the common desire to return to simpler times. The story's protagonist, Charley, is exhausted by life in the mid-20th century, and his generation is especially traumatized from living through both World Wars. He expresses envy of those older than him, such as his grandfather, who he believes was a happier person because he grew up in a kinder, more stable era of history. As a result, when Charley discovers a third level of Grand Central Station that takes him back to 1894, he attempts to buy tickets to permanently return to what he views as a more peaceful and simple time. However, his modern currency prevents him from buying tickets, and though he later obtains enough 19th-century currency to make a life for himself in 1894, he is unable to find the third level again and therefore misses his chance to escape modernity. While Charley's failure initially seems to suggest that a return to the past is impossible, the story reveals that Sam, Charley's psychiatrist who told Charley that the third level was a figment of his imagination, succeeds in finding the third level and time-travelling to live in the past. This twist ending hints that even the most cynical and modern individual can find solace in the past when faced with an unfavorable present. What's more, the

fact that Charley's psychiatrist is the one to leave behind modernity suggests that even the most seemingly emotionally balanced people in modern times still feel the pull of nostalgia.



ESCAPISM

"The Third Level" explores the idea of physical and mental escapism in the face of societal ennui and emotional dissatisfaction. When the protagonist,

Charley, discovers a way to time travel to the past via a hidden third level of Grand Central Station, his psychiatrist, Sam, tells him that what he's experiencing is a waking dream caused by his desire to escape modern life. While Charley does not agree that the third level is a figment of his imagination, he does agree with Sam that he, along with most other modern people, have a desire to escape everyday life due to the unhappy times they live in. However, in contrast to Sam's ideas of escapism via daydreams, Charley's means of escape is a literal exit from the 20th century into 1894, where the low-grade despair of modernity will no longer haunt him. Ironically, this exit is ultimately enjoyed not by Charley but by Sam, who discovers the third level for himself and is able to set up an entirely new life in the past, which he finds significantly more fulfilling than his modern life. Thus, throughout the story, Finney portrays escapism as a means to rid oneself of emotional pain and the dissatisfaction of modern life.



REALITY VS. IMAGINATION

The tension between reality and imagination is a central conflict in "The Third Level." This tension is most clearly embodied by Sam, who is Charley's psychiatrist. When Charley discovers Grand Central Station's third level, which is set in 1894 and could potentially send Charley back in time permanently, Sam disregards his experience as a waking dream. Sam works with the human mind, and his profession as a psychiatrist causes him to chalk Charley's experience up to a mental defect rather than a genuine and transcendental experience. In this way, he represents the pragmatic realist of the modern era, in contrast to the more idealist dreamer that Charley represents in his pursuit of the elusive third level.

However, the story's presentation of what's real and what's not becomes clear at the end, when Sam himself disappears into 1894. While Charley is unable to find the third level after his initial discovery of it, Sam apparently searches for it, finds it, and embraces it. At the end of the story, Charley discovers Sam's fate through a letter in his grandfather's stamp collection: Sam has returned to 1894 and is quite happy there, having become a shopkeeper, since psychiatry is not a profession in the 19th century. By having the story's most pragmatic character be the one to escape into the past, then, Finney invites readers to challenge the modern impulse to disregard anything that doesn't seem realistic, plausible, or

sensible—after all, if Sam can embrace time travel, then seemingly anyone should be able to accept the wondrous and unusual in life.



THE TRAUMA OF WAR

One of the subtler themes of “The Third Level” is the enormous trauma suffered by American society in the aftermath of both World War I and World

War II. The story was published in 1950, which was only a few decades after World War I and a mere five years after World War II. Throughout the story, the protagonist, Charley, laments the anxiety of modern society and yearns for a simpler time when the world was a friendlier place. Much of his desire to travel to the past comes from the fact that it is a time before the World Wars; for instance, he envies his grandfather for having grown up in a time of peace. As a result, when he discovers the third level, which grants him the chance to travel back to 1894, he’s eager to do so in order to live in a time when both World Wars are still a long way off. His desire to escape the present, then, is not so much a means to escape his individual emotional trauma—he’ll still have his own memories of living through the wars—but to escape a society that has been profoundly affected by these wars, to the point that everyone around him is constantly unhappy and distant. In this way, the collective pain of the two World Wars underlies the nostalgia, idealism, and escapism that defines Charley’s character.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



GRAND CENTRAL STATION

Grand Central Station is the primary setting of “The Third Level” and symbolizes the characters’ desire to escape modern society. It is a somewhat complex symbol in that, throughout the story, it represents both the cold complexity of modern life *and* the warm simplicity of the past. In one sense, most of Grand Central Station is a complicated building that people must navigate throughout the course of their hectic daily lives. Charley even likens the station to an enormous tree, whose roots are constantly expanding beneath New York City without anyone even knowing its full sprawl. In this way, most of Grand Central Station represents the inescapable and isolating labyrinth of modern life.

However, this representation of Grand Central Station is inverted with the introduction of the third level, a part of Grand Central Station that is the complete opposite of the rest of the building. While the rest of the station is described primarily in terms of its complexity, the third level, set in 1894, is defined by

specific details such as gaslights and the old-fashioned clothes worn by the people in this part of the station—all things that give the third level a warmer and more lifelike atmosphere. This atmosphere makes sense, given that the third level is a true escape for the characters; it is not a complicated place, as it requires one to merely buy a ticket to return to the past. Thus, in contrast to the rest of Grand Central Station, which represents modern life, the third level is a genuine escape, as represented by its setting in the ostensibly kinder and simpler past.



STAMPS

Charley’s stamp collection represents a bridge between the past and the present throughout “The Third Level.” Early in the story, the collection is established as one that Charley inherited from his grandfather, allowing it to function as a connection across multiple generations of people. In addition, since Charley’s stamp collection was started in an early generation, it allows Charley a window into the past, as the stamps are much older than him and often signify important historical events, as with presidential stamps. In this way, the stamps initially signify Charley’s interest in revisiting the past (although Charley himself denies that his stamp collection is a means of escapism).

At the end of the story, stamps become a much more literal connection between the past and present, as Sam uses it to communicate with Charley and Louisa. After making it to 1894, Sam sends a letter to Charley’s grandfather, knowing that he won’t open it and will place it in his collection due to the new stamp on the back. In the letter, Sam tells Charley that he made it to 1894 and loves it, and he strongly encourages him and Louisa to keep searching for the third level. In other words, Charley’s stamps go from being a more abstract representation of connections between time periods to a literal conduit of communication between them.



GALESBURG, ILLINOIS

The Illinois town of Galesburg symbolizes the past and, specifically, the peace and fulfillment that ostensibly comes from life in a time before the 20th century. Galesburg’s simplicity and peace makes it a prime destination for Charley as he attempts to travel back to 1894, since he views both Galesburg and the 19th century as settings free from the isolation and coldness of modern life. As it turns out, he’s correct in this regard; when Sam finally makes it to 1894 Galesburg, he tells Charley that he loves it there due to the kindness of the neighbors and his simple life as a shopkeeper. In this way, Finney makes Galesburg almost synonymous with 1894 in that they function as an escape from modernity into the simplicity of the United States before the World Wars.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Atria edition of *About Time: 12 Short Stories* published in 1998.

The Third Level Quotes

“I told him about the third level at Grand Central Station, and he said it was a waking-dream wish fulfillment. He said I was unhappy. That made my wife kind of mad, but he explained that he meant the modern world is full of insecurity, fear, war, worry and all the rest of it, and that I just want to escape. Well, hell, who doesn’t? Everyone I know wants to escape, but they don’t wander down into any third level at Grand Central Station.”

Related Characters: Charley (speaker), Charley’s Psychiatrist (Sam), Louisa

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 11

Explanation and Analysis

After telling his psychiatrist friend about discovering the third level, Charley’s friend responds by rationalizing the event as a form of mental escapism that Charley is subconsciously partaking in. The psychiatrist’s rationale is that the modern world is an unhappy place, so it’s natural that Charley would want to escape it. However, Charley refutes this explanation by arguing that he’s not unique in wanting to escape; according to him, everyone wants to get away from the modern world.

This quote is significant in that it highlights the tension Charley has with the status quo. Charley, in accepting his experience with the third level, shows himself to be open to unusual experiences. In contrast, his psychiatrist friend represents the pragmatism and realism viewed as the norm in the modern age.

In addition to highlighting Charley’s conflict with society, this quote also gives the reader another important bit of information: modern society is a miserable place, at least according to Charley, and most people want to escape it. The theme of escaping modernity is crucial throughout the story.

“My stamp collecting, for example; that’s a “temporary refuge from reality.” Well, maybe, but my grandfather didn’t need any refuge from reality; things were pretty nice and peaceful in his day, from all I hear, and he started my collection.”

Related Characters: Charley (speaker)

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 11

Explanation and Analysis

To give him another example of his escapist tendencies, Charley’s friends cite his hobby of collecting stamps as a way that he temporarily gets away from reality. Charley disagrees with this, since his grandfather was the one who started his stamp collection despite growing up in peaceful times.

This quote further deepens the tension between the past and present by introducing generational differences. Charley has established that he believes modern society is broken; in contrast, his grandfather grew up in peaceful times, which further emphasizes the misery of modernity. This is underscored by the subtle envy in Charley’s tone as he discusses the happier times of his grandfather’s era.

Furthermore, Charley describing his grandfather’s time as “peaceful” highlights a major reason modern times are worse: World Wars I and II. Since this story is set in the 1950s, both wars are fresh in everyone’s minds. In other words, compared to his grandfather’s peers, Charley’s generation has been collectively traumatized by war.

“Sometimes I think Grand Central is growing like a tree, pushing out new corridors and staircases like roots. There’s probably a long tunnel that nobody knows about feeling its way under the city right now, on its way to Time Square, and maybe another to Central Park. And maybe—because for so many people through the years Grand Central *has* been an exit, a way of escape—maybe that’s how the tunnel I got into...”

Related Characters: Charley (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 12

Explanation and Analysis

In recounting the experience of getting lost throughout Grand Central Station, Charley compares the station to a massive tree that is constantly growing. The station's "roots" in this simile are the various corridors that spread underneath New York City. Charley muses that there might be corridors that nobody has even heard of. As he muses, he trails off while considering the implications of Grand Central Station being an escape, and he seems to think of some sort of connection between his theory and his encounter with the third level.

Charley's comparison between Grand Central Station and a giant tree reflects the story's greater themes regarding modernity and urbanity. The theoretical corridors Charley describes are complex and impossible to know in full, symbolizing the difficulty of modern life.

The way that Charley trails off at the end before fully completing his thought introduces mystery and suspense into the story, as he suggests a link between the station's complexity and his encounter with the third level. By following his theory, Charley implies something supernatural about the station as it continues to grow of his own volition, and he even implies that it may have other dimensions besides the third level for those that wish to escape society. He follows this thought to its logical conclusion and begins to wonder if his desire to escape also opened the route to the third level for him.

☞ There were brass spittoons on the floor, and across the station a glint of light caught my eye; a man was pulling a gold watch from his vest pocket. He snapped open the cover, glanced at his watch, and frowned. He wore a derby hat, a black four-button suit with tiny lapels, and he had a big, black, handle-bar mustache. Then I looked around and saw that everyone in the station was dressed like eighteen-ninety-something; I never saw so many bears, sideburns and fancy mustaches in my life.

Related Characters: Charley (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 13

Explanation and Analysis

After arriving on the third level, Charley observes his surroundings and immediately notices many unusual things.

He notices spittoons—receptacles for spitting into—as well as the unusual attire of a nearby man. As he looks around, he realizes everyone is in old-style attire.

This passage has the most imagery out of any in the story, which makes sense given that its purpose is to establish the titular third level. Finney introduces details slowly at first, starting with the slightly unusual detail of the spittoon. From there, he transitions to the man's golden watch. Both of these details provide clues as to the level's time period. The more in-depth description of the man's attire suggests that something strange is going on, which is further illustrated by the revelation that *everyone* is dressed in outdated attire. By doing this, Finney slowly reveals the true nature of the third level: it is from the 19th century.

☞ Have you ever been there? It's a wonderful town still, with big old frame houses, huge lawns and tremendous trees whose branches meet overhead and roof the streets. And in 1894, summer evenings were twice as long, and people sat out on their lawns, the men smoking cigars and talking quietly, the women waving palm-leaf fans, with the fireflies all around, in a peaceful world. To be back there with the First World War still twenty years off, and World War II over forty years in the future ... I wanted two tickets for that.

Related Characters: Charley (speaker)

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

Charley describes Galesburg, Illinois, the town he hopes to travel to in 1894. He describes it in glowing terms due to its old houses, large trees, and friendly people. While Charley still loves Galesburg in the present, he longs to see it in the 19th century, since he believes it will be especially lovely in a time before the two World Wars.

His description of Galesburg is a direct contrast to that of New York City. While New York is cold, hectic, and impersonal, the imagery associated with Galesburg establishes it as a warm and peaceful place. This is especially evident in its descriptions of people; while the people in the 1950s are constantly in a hurry, moving throughout Grand Central Station, the people in 1894 Galesburg are able to partake in leisure activities such as smoking cigars. The

imagery surrounding it is romantic and almost dreamlike, manifesting as an ideal life for Charley.

Charley credits the peace and warmth of 1894 Galesburg specifically to the fact that it is a period before the two World Wars. This is the ultimate divider between happiness and misery for Charley when looking at history: he views the era before the wars as joyous and calm, and everything afterwards as chaotic and cold. This differentiation shows how profound the impact of the World Wars were both on Charley as an individual and on society collectively.

☞ He nodded at the bills. “That ain’t money, mister,” he said, “and if you’re trying to skin me you won’t get very far,” and he glanced at the cash drawer beside him. Of course the money in his drawer was old-style bills, half again as big the money we use nowadays, and different-looking. I turned away and got out fast. There’s nothing nice about jail, even in 1894.

Related Characters: Charley, The Clerk (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

Charley attempts to buy tickets to Galesburg, but the clerk won’t accept his modern currency; money in 1894 looked different and was much smaller. Sensing that the clerk is suspicious of him, Charley quickly leaves, not wanting to get arrested.

This encounter serves as the moment in which Charley ultimately fails to accomplish his goal of making it to 1894 Galesburg. Significantly, his failure comes about because of his modernity; his present-day money marks him as an outsider and attracts suspicion. The fact that Charley’s existence as a 1950s individual bars him from 1894 suggests that bridging the past and present might not be as easy as he believes.

Charley’s fear of getting arrested also hints at the less idealized side of the 19th century, when individuals had comparatively fewer legal rights and it was easier to get arrested for trivial matters. While the story largely portrays the past in a rosy light, this interaction provides a subtle counterpoint to the idea that the past was perfect.

☞ My friend Sam Weiner disappeared! Nobody knew where, but I sort of suspected because Sam’s a city boy, and I used to tell him about Galesburg—I went to school there—and he always said he liked the sound of the place.

Related Characters: Charley (speaker), Charley’s Psychiatrist (Sam)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 15

Explanation and Analysis

Although Charley is unable to make it to the third level, he suspects that his friend Sam made it there after Sam’s disappearance. Although Sam grew up in the city, he always liked hearing about Galesburg from Charley, hence Charley’s hunch that he returned to 1894 Galesburg.

The revelation of Sam’s disappearance is significant in that it provides a hint that Charley was right: the third level wasn’t simply in his head. If Charley is correct about his hunch, it also vindicates his belief that he is not the only one trying to escape. Indeed, the fact that Sam was drawn to Galesburg in the past already supports this; as a city boy, Sam should be most adjusted to the trials of modern and urban life, but instead, he too wishes to live in a more peaceful and suburban location. This suggests that the urge to flee modernity and urbanity is a universal desire, rather than something unique to Charley.

☞ Charley, it’s true; I found the third level! I’ve been here two weeks, and right now, down the street at the Daly’s, someone is playing a piano, and they’re all out on the front porch singing, “Seeing Nellie home.” And I’m invited over for lemonade. Come on back, Charley and Louisa. Keep looking till you find the third level! It’s worth it, believe me!

Related Characters: Charley’s Psychiatrist (Sam) (speaker), Charley, Louisa

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

In a letter to Charley sent through his grandfather's stamp collection, Sam confirms Charley's suspicion that he made it to the third level. Sam describes Galesburg as a wonderful place, where everyone is playing music and he's invited over to the neighbor's house for lemonade. He tells Charley and Louisa to keep looking for the third level, insisting that it's worth it.

The fact that Sam went to 1894 Galesburg vindicates the worldview Charley has expressed throughout the story: namely, that the past is better than the present and that Galesburg specifically is a wonderful place to be, especially in the 19th century. Sam's descriptions of Galesburg, specifically his neighbor's hospitality, echoes Charley's earlier fantasy of 1894 Galesburg as being full of friendly, happy people that always have time to spend together. In this way, Sam's discovery of 1894 Galesburg and its consistency with Charley's assumptions suggests that the past truly is better than the present—at least within the story's worldview.

☞ I found out that Sam bought eight hundred dollars' worth of old-style currency. That ought to set him up in a nice little hay, feed, and grain business; he always said that's what he really wished he could do, and he certainly can't go back to his old business. Not in Galesburg, Illinois, in 1894. His old business? Why, Sam was my psychiatrist.

Related Characters: Charley (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

After receiving Sam's letter, Charley later discovers that he bought \$800 of old currency, which would be enough for him to set up a business in 1894, since Sam cannot continue his present-day profession in 1894 Galesburg. Charley reveals that this is because Sam is his psychiatrist friend, who initially told him at the beginning of the story that his encounter with the third level was in his imagination.

The story's twist ending—that Sam, the one person who was able to make it to 1894, is Charley's psychiatrist—suggests that the romanticism of the past is stronger than the pragmatism of the present. From the beginning of the story, Sam has functioned as the cynic of the story who chooses to

look for a rational explanation rather than buying into the fantastical as Charley has. In reality, however, Sam strives for the past just as Charley does. This suggests that his pragmatism is a façade and that he is just as lost in the present day as Charley is.

Sam's change of profession also serves as a subtle criticism of the increasing complexity of science and technology. Throughout the story, Sam's practice of psychiatry has served as an obstacle and annoyance rather than something that could genuinely increase Charley's understanding of himself. Thus, when Sam chooses to open a simple shop back in 1894 and abandon his practice of psychiatry, it's portrayed as a progression for his character and a credit to the past that it does not have such complicated professions.

☞ Now, I don't know why this should have happened to me. I'm just an ordinary guy named Charley, thirty-one years old, and I was wearing a tan gabardine suit and a straw hat with a fancy band; I passed a dozen men who looked just like me. And I wasn't trying to escape from anything; I just wanted to get home to Louisa, my wife.

Related Characters: Charley (speaker)

Related Themes:  

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Explanation and Analysis

Right before recounting his encounter with the third level, Charley introduces himself to the reader. He gives his name and describes himself as extremely ordinary, to the point that he looks exactly the same as multiple men he passed in the station. He also claims that he has no specific aspiration in mind other than to get home to his wife.

Finney's portrayal of Charley as an exceedingly normal and almost boring person follows the archetype in science fiction of an "everyman" protagonist, where the protagonist is an ordinary person that finds themselves in an extraordinary situation. The everyman protagonist often serves as an audience surrogate, allowing readers to see themselves more directly in the story's main character.

In addition, Charley's self-introduction also serves as a subtle refutation of his friends' claims that he has escapist tendencies, as he claims that his only objective in the station was to get home. In this way, Charley uses his ordinariness as a symbol of his reliability as a narrator.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

THE THIRD LEVEL

Charley insists that there is a third level to New York's **Grand Central Station**, even though everyone else insists there are only two. Although he claims to have visited it, his psychiatrist says that his experience is nothing more than mental escapism from the modern world. Charley acknowledges that he wants to escape, but he also points out that everyone wants to escape the modern world due to its instability and war—and yet, not everyone imagines extra floors to Grand Central Station. Charley's friends also point to his stamp-collecting habit as evidence of his tendency towards escapism, but he refutes this by arguing that his grandfather grew up in more peaceful times but still collected **stamps**.

Charley turns to recounting his discovery of the third level. On his way home from work, he decides to take the subway, since it will get him home faster from work—a detail he uses to point out that he is not trying to escape anything, but merely trying to get home to his wife Louisa. In attempting to find his train, he gets lost in the station. According to him, this is a common occurrence due to the building's convoluted architecture. He idly speculates that **Grand Central Station** is “growing like a tree, pushing out new corridors and staircases like roots.”

Charley continues down a long corridor in silence for a while. He then begins to hear the commotion of people ahead. Exiting the tunnel, he comes out onto the third level. Various details, such as open-flame gaslights, brass spittoons, and everyone's 19th-century clothes hint to him that something's strange, but it isn't until he sees a Currier & Ives train that he realizes that he has travelled into the past. He checks a newspaper and sees that it's an issue of *The World*, which has not been published in many years. The specific issue mentions President Cleveland—Charley notes that he will later track the issue down in the library and discover that it is from 1894.

The story's opening immediately introduces its primary point of tension: the ideological conflict between the protagonist, Charley, and modern society. Although Charley knows that he discovered a secret level to Grand Central Station, his peers point to his idealist and escapist tendencies as evidence that he imagined the whole thing. Charley, however, counters this by suggesting that the dissatisfaction he feels is no different from anyone else living in the difficult modern era. In other words, while Charley's friends believe that something is wrong with Charley, Charley instead believes that something is wrong with modern society.



Charley's musings about the station's architecture further illustrate the story's theme of escapism from modernity. The station is a massive industrial structure that Charley gets lost in while trying to get home; in this way, he is literally swallowed up by modernity. His musings that Grand Central Station is constantly growing also implies that modernity is an unstoppable force that continues to spread across society, despite the unhappiness and aimlessness that it causes.



In contrast to the cold and intimidating imagery of the station up to this point, when the third level is revealed, it is a vibrant, warm, and fascinating place. Whereas the story has been relatively scant on setting description, Finney now includes a variety of details from the platform and the people that occupy it. These details lead up to the revelation that the third level is set in the past, specifically 1894. In this way, the narrative uses imagery and description to associate the past with a warmer and livelier atmosphere than the modern present.



Upon realizing he has travelled into the past, Charley immediately approaches the ticket gate with the intention of buying two tickets to **Galesburg, Illinois** for Louisa and himself. Galesburg, he claims, is a beautiful town even in the present, thanks to its enormous houses, trees, and lawns. Charley believes it would be even more lovely in 1894, where summer evenings are longer, neighborhoods are more tranquil, and both World Wars are still decades away. In buying the tickets, he hopes that he and his wife can become part of this peaceful world.

Charley has enough money for two one-way tickets, but when he attempts to pay, the clerk refuses to accept his modern currency. Charley, not wanting to get arrested, quickly leaves. The next day, he spends \$300—nearly all the money he and Louisa have—in order to get less than \$200 in old currency, rationalizing his decision by pointing out that inflation means that his money in 1894 is worth a great deal more. However, he is unable to find the third level again.

After his failure, Charley initially gives up on searching for the third level at Louisa's insistence and goes back to his stamp collection. However, he and Louisa both eventually pick up the search again after his friend Sam disappears. Although nobody knows where Sam went, Charley suspects that Sam found the third level and went to 1894 **Galesburg**. His reasoning is that, even though Sam is a city boy, he always seemed deeply drawn to Galesburg whenever Charley talked to him about it.

One night, while looking through his **stamp** collection, Charley finds a first-day cover—a letter mailed with a stamp on the first day of that stamp's sale. The stamp was mailed to Charley's grandfather and is postmarked July 18, 1894, with a six-cent stamp of President Garfield on the envelope. Charley has never seen this first-day cover in his collection before, so he opens it. Inside is a letter to Charley from his friend Sam, who tells Charley that he made it to 1894 **Galesburg** and loves it. Later, Charley discovers that Sam bought \$800 of old currency, which would be enough for him to set up a new business. And setting up a new business would be necessary, Sam notes, because psychiatry didn't exist in 1894, and Sam was a psychiatrist—in fact, he was Charley's psychiatrist.

Charley's immediate desire to travel to the past drives home the story's positive depiction of nostalgia. Specifically, Charley's romantic notion of the past is represented by Galesburg, a suburban town that stands in stark contrast to the cramped and urban New York City. Charley also has an especially strong desire to live in a time before World Wars I and II, implying that the trauma of the two wars is a major reason modern society is such a miserable place.



When Charley attempts to pay for the tickets, the clerk's suspicious reaction to his modern currency serves as a painful reminder of Charley's place in modern society. This point is further driven home when, after fleeing the third level and going to buy old currency, he is unable to find the third level again. Although Charley was able to get a glimpse of the happier and easier past, his existence as a modern person has doomed him to continue his current life in the 20th century.



Like Charley, Sam is also drawn to Galesburg as a symbol of peace and simplicity. This is especially notable since, unlike Charley, Sam grew up in New York City and therefore would seemingly be more attuned to modern urbanity than the more idealist Charley—but, as it turns out, Sam is as weary of modernity as Charley is, vindicating Charley's earlier implication that everyone is unhappy in the 20th century.



The story's ending connects the past and present through Charley's stamp collection, which allows Sam to contact him and confirm Charley's suspicions that Sam successfully made it to 1894 Galesburg. Furthermore, the twist that Sam is Charley's psychiatrist is extremely significant in that, throughout the story, Charley's psychiatrist has represented the pragmatism of modern life. That Sam, rather than Charley, is the one to successfully make it to 1894 highlights the superiority of the past over the present, as it implies that even someone who has entered a field as modern as psychiatry secretly craves a simpler, more nostalgic life.





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